

Gradient Pulse — AI News, Explained

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What shipped

- Claude Opus 5.5 shipped September 22 — first model in the new Claude 5.5 family; Anthropic calls it "its most powerful AI model to date" (VENDOR CLAIM); live on AWS, Google Cloud, Azure. — [Anthropic \(company claim\)](#)
- Claims new SOTA in coding/knowledge work, outpacing the larger Fable 5.1 on many tests: Terminal-Bench 4.0 66.4% (vs Opus 5 52.3%), FrontierCode v1.1 54.4%, CursorBench 4.0 57.8%, GDPval-AA v2.1 1846, HLE 67.7% with tools, OSWorld 2.0 81.8% — no independent rerun attached. — [Anthropic \(self-reported benchmarks\)](#)
- Priced at \$4/\$20 per 1M tokens (20% below Opus 5's \$5/\$25); cache reads \$0.50 → \$0.20 (60% cheaper); ~40% lower operating cost on typical workloads; 30%+ faster generation; fast mode up to 2.5x at \$8/\$40. — [Anthropic / Reuters](#)
- Safety: 85% less likely to bypass containment boundaries than Opus 5/Mythos 5.1 (internal test); ties Fable 5.1 for lowest prompt-injection success rate on Gray Swan's benchmark; ships under Fable-level safeguards — cyber queries route to Opus 4.8, biology via Life Sciences Verification Program; pre-release testing by Frontier Design and METR. — [Anthropic \(internal evals\)](#)
- Sonnet 5.5 + Haiku 5.5 "in the coming weeks"; five-hour subscriber usage limits up 20%; model marketed as writing with less jargon and key info first. — [Anthropic](#)

The pacing-pledge frame

- First frontier-lab release since CEO Dario Amodei's pace-the-frontier essay earlier in September; 2 months after Opus 5 (July 24); resolves the Sept 19 monitor item that Anthropic was "weighing another Claude model." — [TechCrunch / Reuters](#)
- The capability jump is efficiency, not scale: cheaper, faster, more contained — same Fable-level safeguards, not weaker ones. Bear case: 2 months between releases is not slow, and "40% cheaper" is a competitive weapon aimed at OpenAI and low-cost Chinese labs. — [Gradient Pulse analysis](#)
- Third reading: the pledge was about the riskiest leaps (bio, cyber, autonomous replication) — Opus 5.5 routes around those (cyber → Opus 4.8, biology → verification program), so Anthropic can claim pacing on danger while shipping the profitable middle. — [Gradient Pulse analysis](#)

Hype Check: the benchmark gap

- Every headline figure is Anthropic's own or a partner's as quoted by Anthropic — none independently replicated at time of writing; the 40% savings is measured at each model's DEFAULT effort (medium on 5.5 vs high on 5) while headline benchmarks ran at MAX effort. — [Digital Applied \(analysis of Anthropic's numbers\)](#)
- Rival-model scores in Anthropic's tables are Anthropic's own runs of those rivals, not the labs' published results — the same move xAI made with Grok 4.7 (flagged in the Sept 21 special). — [Gradient Pulse analysis](#)

- VERDICT: UNPROVEN. Not overblown — unlike Grok 4.7, no independent data contradicts the numbers yet; they are simply unverified. The price list (\$4/\$20) is the confirmed part — printed, public, payable today. Watch Artificial Analysis and independent coding evals for the rerun. — [Gradient Pulse analysis](#)

Release radar + perf-per-dollar

- Perf-per-dollar spotlight: \$4/\$20 vs Opus 5's \$5/\$25; Anthropic claims Terminal-Bench parity with GPT-6 Astra at ~40% of cost per task, CursorBench beating GPT-5.6 Sol by 11 points at ~a third of the cost (vendor math). — [Anthropic](#)
- Release radar: Opus 5.5 ships today; Sonnet 5.5 + Haiku 5.5 coming weeks; incumbents are GPT-6 Astra and Fable 5.1; Meta's Muse Spark 1.3 made its own efficiency pitch Sept 2. Frontier pricing is falling — 20% list cuts, 60% cheaper cache reads where agentic coding bills accumulate. — [Gradient Pulse analysis](#)

Sources: [Anthropic \(company claim\)](#) · [Anthropic \(self-reported benchmarks\)](#) · [Anthropic / Reuters](#) · [Anthropic \(internal evals\)](#) · [Anthropic · TechCrunch / Reuters](#) · [Gradient Pulse analysis](#) · [Gradient Pulse analysis](#) · [Digital Applied \(analysis of Anthropic's numbers\)](#) · [Gradient Pulse analysis](#) · [Anthropic](#) · [Gradient Pulse analysis](#)

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